

Ron Pomper

Curriculum Vitae

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Contact Information

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Positions & Education

2024- **Assistant Professor**
 Department of Communicative Sciences and Disorders
 Michigan State University

2020-2024 **Postdoctoral Research Fellow**
 Boys Town National Research Hospital
 Advisor: Karla McGregor

2014-2020 **Ph.D. in Developmental Psychology**
 University of Wisconsin-Madison
 Advisor: Jenny Saffran

2013-2014 **M.S. in Developmental Psychology**
 University of Wisconsin-Madison
 Advisor: Jenny Saffran

2007-2011 **B.A. in Human Biology**, conferred with Departmental Honors
 and conferred with Distinction
 Stanford University
 Advisor: Anne Fernald

Research Interests

Word learning; typical and atypical language development; Developmental Language Disorder; Autism Spectrum Disorder; semantic and phonological knowledge; speech processing

Awards, Fellowships, & Grants

2022-2024	NIH NRSA F32 Postdoctoral Fellowship (\$ 136,674) F32DC020344: Phonological networks and novel word learning by children with developmental language disorder, National Institute on Deafness and Other Communication Disorders (NIDCD)
2022	ASHA Lessons for Success Program , mentored by Dr. Jana Iverson, American Speech-Language-Hearing Association
2021-2022	ASHA Pathways Program , mentored by Dr. Sara Kover, American Speech-Language-Hearing Association
2017-2019	NIH NRSA F31 Predoctoral Fellowship , individual NRSA from the NICHD (\$63,324) F31HD091969: Combining cues in word learning, Eunice Kennedy Shriver National Institute of Child Health and Human Development (NICHD)
2017-2019	Morse Scholarship , Waisman Center, University of Wisconsin-Madison
2015-2017	Trainee , NIDCD (T32DC005359): Interdisciplinary research training in speech-language disorders
2014-2015	Trainee , NICHD (T32HD049899): Training in Language: Acquisition and adult performance
2013-2014	University Distinguished Graduate Fellowship , UW-Madison
2012	German Academic Exchange Service (DAAD) scholar , University of Saarland, Germany
2011	Phi Beta Kappa , Stanford University, CA
2011	Firestone Medal , for excellence in Undergraduate Research Stanford University, CA
2010	Undergraduate and Advising Research (UAR) Major Grant Stanford University, CA

Scholarship

* indicates a student first-author

Journal Articles (peer-reviewed)

17. McGregor, K. M., **Pomper, R.**, Eden, N., Appenzeller, M., Arbisi-Kelm, T., Polese, E., & Reed, D. K. (2024). Inferring Word Class and Meaning From Spoken and Written Texts: A Comparison of Children With and Without Developmental Language Disorder. *Journal of Speech, Language, and Hearing Research*, 67(12), 4783-4798. DOI: [10.1044/2024.JSLHR-23-00743](https://doi.org/10.1044/2024.JSLHR-23-00743)
16. Mathée-Scott, J., Prescott, K. E., **Pomper, R.**, Saffran, J., & Ellis Weismer, S. (2024). Prediction by Young Autistic Children from Visual and Spoken Input. *Journal of Autism and Developmental Disorders*, 1-13. DOI: [10.1007/s10803-024-06568-z](https://doi.org/10.1007/s10803-024-06568-z)
15. *Hearnshaw, S., Baker, E., **Pomper, R.**, McGregor, K. K., Edwards, J., & Munro, N. (2024). Four cases of children with phonological impairment and precocious vocabulary: making sense of a clinical conundrum. *American Journal of Speech-Language Pathology*, 33(5), 2230-2248. DOI: [10.1044/2024.AJSLP-23-00370](https://doi.org/10.1044/2024.AJSLP-23-00370)
14. *Hearnshaw, S., Baker, E., **Pomper, R.**, McGregor, K. K., Edwards, J., & Munro, N. (2024). I remembered the chorm! Word learning abilities of children with and without phonological impairment. *International Journal of Language & Communication Disorders*, 59(3), 913-931. DOI: [10.1111/1460-6984.12967](https://doi.org/10.1111/1460-6984.12967)
13. *Hearnshaw, S., Baker, E., **Pomper, R.**, McGregor, K. K., Edwards, J., & Munro, N. (2023). The relationship between speech perception, speech production, and vocabulary abilities in children: Insights from by-group and continuous analyses. *Journal of Speech, Language, and Hearing Research*, 66(4), 1173-1191. DOI: [10.1044/2022.JLSHR-22-00441](https://doi.org/10.1044/2022.JLSHR-22-00441)
12. **Pomper, R.**, McGregor, K. K., Arbisi-Kelm, T., Eden, N., & Ohlmann, N. (2022). Direct instruction improves word learning for children with Developmental Language Disorder. *Journal of Speech, Language, and Hearing Research*, 65(11), 4228-4249. DOI: [10.1044/2022.JSLHR-22-00300](https://doi.org/10.1044/2022.JSLHR-22-00300)
11. Mathée-Scott, J., Larson, C., Venker, C., **Pomper, R.**, Edwards, J., Saffran, J., & Ellis Weismer, S. (2022). Use of mutual exclusivity and its relationship to language ability in toddlers with Autism Spectrum Disorder. *Journal of Autism and Developmental Disorders*, 52(10), 4528-4539. DOI: [10.1007/s10803-021-05321-0](https://doi.org/10.1007/s10803-021-05321-0)

10. Zettersten, M., **Pomper, R.**, & Saffran, J. (2022). Valid points and looks: Reliability and validity go hand-in-hand when improving infant methods. *Infant and Child Development*, 31(5), e2326. DOI: [10.1002/icd.2326](https://doi.org/10.1002/icd.2326).
9. **Pomper, R.**, Kaushanskaya, M., & Saffran, J. (2022). Change is hard: Individual differences in children's lexical processing and executive functions after a shift in dimensions. *Language Learning and Development*, 18(2), 229-247 DOI: [10.1080/15475441.2021.1947289](https://doi.org/10.1080/15475441.2021.1947289)
8. McGregor, K. K., Smolak, E., Jones, M., Oleson, J., Eden, N., Arbisi-Kelm, T., & **Pomper, R.** (2022). What children with Developmental Language Disorder teach us about cross-situational word learning. *Cognitive Science*, 46(2), e13094. DOI: [10.1111/cogs.13094](https://doi.org/10.1111/cogs.13094)
7. McGregor, K. K., **Pomper, R.**, Eden, N., Arbisi-Kelm, T., Ohlmann, N., Gajre, S., & Smolak, E. (2021). Children's language abilities predict success in remote communication contexts. *Language Development Research*, 1(1), 245-282. DOI: [10.34842/8jgf-r802](https://doi.org/10.34842/8jgf-r802)
6. **Pomper, R.**, Ellis Weismer, S., Saffran, J., & Edwards, J. (2021). Coarticulation facilitates lexical processing for toddlers with autism. *Cognition*, 214, 104799. DOI: [10.1016/j.cognition.2021.104799](https://doi.org/10.1016/j.cognition.2021.104799)
5. Venker, C. E., **Pomper, R.**, Mahr, T., Edwards, J., Saffran, J., & Ellis Weismer, S. (2020). Comparing automatic eye tracking and manual gaze coding methods in young children with Autism Spectrum Disorder. *Autism Research*, 13(2), 271-283. DOI: [10.1002/aur.2225](https://doi.org/10.1002/aur.2225)
4. **Pomper, R.**, Ellis Weismer, S., Saffran, J., & Edwards, J. (2019). Specificity of phonological representations for children with Autism Spectrum Disorder. *Journal of Autism and Developmental Disorders*, 49(8), 3351-3363. DOI: [10.1007/s10803-019-04054-5](https://doi.org/10.1007/s10803-019-04054-5)
3. *Breen, E., **Pomper, R.**, & Saffran, J.R. (2019). Phonological learning influences label-object mapping in toddlers. *Journal of Speech, Language, and Hearing Research*, 62(6), 1923-1932. DOI: [10.1044/2019_JSLHR-L-18-0131](https://doi.org/10.1044/2019_JSLHR-L-18-0131)
2. **Pomper, R.**, & Saffran, J. R. (2019). Familiar object salience affects novel word learning. *Child Development*, 90(2), e246-e262. DOI: [10.1111/cdev.13053](https://doi.org/10.1111/cdev.13053)
1. **Pomper, R.**, & Saffran, J. R. (2016). Roses are red, socks are blue: Switching dimensions disrupts young children's language processing. *PLoS ONE*, 11(6), e0158459. DOI: [10.1371/journal.pone.0158459](https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pone.0158459)

Code & Software

Olson, R. H., **Pomper, R.**, Potter, C. E., Hay, J. F., Saffran, J. R., Ellis Weismer, S., & Lew-Williams, C. (2020). Peyecoder: An open-source program for coding eye movements (Version v1.0.2-beta). Zenodo. <http://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.3939234>

Invited Presentations

Pomper, R. (2025, October). Facilitating word learning for children with and without Developmental Language Disorder. University of Michigan Developmental Psychology Brown Bag.

Lancaster, H., Gordon, K. R., **Pomper, R.**, & LaRose, A. (2024, April). Developmental Language Disorder: Key Characteristics and Variability. ASHA CEU Webinar.

Refereed Conference Presentations

Pomper, R., McGregor, K. K., & Vitevitch, M. S. (2025, November). Phonological Networks: A Shiny app for calculating phonological features of real and made-up words using adult and child lexicons. Poster presented at the 66th Annual Meeting of the Psychonomic Society, Denver, CO.

Pomper, R., McGregor, K. K., & Vitevitch, M. S. (2025, May). Age-related changes in the effect of vocabulary structure on children's word learning. Poster presented at the Symposium for Research on Child Language Disorders, Madison, WI.

Pomper, R., Gray, S., Munro, N., Goffman, L., & Benham, S. (2024, June). Associations and dissociations between phonological and semantic aspects of word learning. Symposium presented at the XVIth International Congress for the Study of Child Language, Prague, Czech Republic.

Pomper, R., McGregor, K. K., & Vitevitch, M. S. (2024, May). Measuring phonological structure of children's vocabularies using a lexical decision task. Poster presented at the Symposium for Research on Child Language Disorders, Madison, WI.

Pomper, R., Reed, D. K., Eden, N., Arbisi-Kelm, T., & McGregor, K. K. (2023, June). How children with and without Developmental Language Disorder infer word meaning from written and spoken text. Poster presented at the Symposium for Research on Child Language Disorders, Madison, WI.

Pomper, R., Arbisi-Kelm, T., Eden, N., & McGregor, K. (2022, June). Separating presentation of words and their referents facilitates learning for children

- with and without Developmental Language Disorder. Poster presented at the Symposium for Research on Child Language Disorders, Madison, WI.
- Bacon, D., **Pomper, R.**, & Saffran, J. (2022, April). Peas are green: testing toddlers' associations of colors with familiar objects. Poster presented at Cognitive Development Society Bi-Ennial Conference, Madison, WI.
- Mathée-Scott, J., Larson, C., Venker, C., **Pomper R.**, Edwards, J., Saffran, J., & Ellis Weismer, S. (2021, November). Use of Mutual Exclusivity and Relationship to Language Ability in Toddlers with Autism Spectrum Disorder. Oral Presentation at the Annual Convention of the American Speech-Language-Hearing Association, Washington, DC.
- McGregor, K., **Pomper, R.**, Eden, N., Arbisi-Kelm, T., Ohlmann, N., Gajre, S., & Smolak, E. (2021, June). Children's Success in Remote Communication Contexts Varies with Language Ability. Poster presented at the Symposium for Research on Child Language Disorders, Madison, WI.
- Mathée, J., Larson, C., Venker, C., **Pomper R.**, Edwards, J., Saffran, J., & Ellis Weismer, S. (2021, June). Mutual Exclusivity and Language Ability in Toddlers with Autism Spectrum Disorder. Poster presented at the Symposium for Research on Child Language Disorders, Madison, WI.
- Pomper, R.** (2021, April). When One is Not Enough: Children's Ability to Combine Cues in Novel Word Learning. Flash Talk presented at the Society for Research in Child Development Biennial Meeting.
- Pomper, R.**, McGregor, K., Eden, N., Arbisi-Kelm, T., Ohlmann, N. (2021, April). Direct and Indirect Novel Word Learning Abilities for Children with Developmental Language Disorder. Flash Talk presented at the SRCD 2021 Biennial Meeting.
- Pomper, R.**, Kaushanskaya, M., & Saffran, J. (2019, November). Changing dimensions affects older children's language processing. Poster presented at the Boston University Conference on Language Development, Boston, MA.
- Pomper, R.**, Saffran, J., Ellis Weismer, S., & Edwards, J. (2019, November). Effect of coarticulation on language processing for children with autism. Poster presented at the Boston University Conference on Language Development, Boston, MA.
- Pomper, R.**, Kaushanskaya, M., & Saffran, J. (2019, October). Disruptions in children's lexical processing following changes in dimensions and the relation to age and executive function. Poster presented at the Cognitive Development Society Biennial Conference, Louisville, KY.

Pomper, R., & Saffran, J.R. (2018, July). More than distractors: Familiar objects influence toddlers' semantic representations in novel word learning. Poster presented at the XXI ICIS Biennial Congress, Philadelphia, PA.

Pomper, R., Ellis Weismer, S., Saffran, J.R., Mahr, T., & Edwards, J. (2018, June). Phonological representations in children with Autism Spectrum Disorder. Poster presented at the Symposium on Research in Child Language Disorders, Madison, WI.

Breen, E., **Pomper, R., & Saffran, J.R.** (2017, November). Connecting phonotactic learning and word learning in infancy. Poster presented at the Boston University Conference on Language Development, Boston, MA.

Pomper, R., & Saffran, J.R. (2017, April). Switching dimensions disrupts young children's language comprehension. Poster presented at the Society for Research in Child Development, Austin, TX.

Pomper, R., & Saffran, J. R. (2015, October). Salient competitors in novel word learning. Poster presented at the Ninth Biennial Meeting of the Cognitive Development Society, Columbus, OH.

Pomper, R., Potter, C., Benitez, V.L., & Saffran, J.R. (2015, June). Segmenting words of varying length: Statistics don't always win. Oral presentation given at the International Conference on Interdisciplinary Advances in Statistical Learning, San Sebastian, Spain.

Fernald, A. & **Pomper, R.** (2011, March). For toddlers too, the search for the object begins at the verb. Oral presentation at the CUNY Conference on Human Sentence Processing, Stanford, CA.

Fernald, A. & **Pomper, R.** (2010, September). For toddlers too, the search for the object begins at the verb. Oral presentation at the Conceptual Structure, Discourse and Language and Embodied and Situated Language Processing Conference, San Diego, CA.

Teaching & Mentoring Experience

2025- **Mentor**, ASHA Mentoring Academic-Research Careers (MARC)

2024- **Instructor**, Language Development (CSD 333)

2024- **Instructor**, Developmental Language Disorders (CSD 824)

2023-2024	Research Mentor , Innovative Mentoring and Professional Advancement through Cultural Training (IMPACT)
2023-2024	Mentor , Cognitive Development Society Mentorship Program
2022	Co-Instructor , Eye-tracking workshop at Ohio State University
2019	Instructor , Child Development (Psych 460)
2018	Instructor , Current Topics in Psychology (Psych 601) Deficit or Difference? Interpreting Diverse Developmental Pathways
2018	Research Mentor , Psychology Research Experience Program, UW-Madison
2017-2018	Participant , Leadership Institute, Office for Equity and Diversity, UW-Madison
2017	Research Mentor , PEOPLE Program Summer Internship, UW-Madison
2016	Teaching Assistant , Cognitive Development (Psychology 502)
2016	Teaching Assistant , Child Development (Psychology 560)
2011-2012	Core Course Associate , the Program in Human Biology, Stanford University
2009	Teaching Assistant , Language Understanding by Children and Adults (Psych 7Q), Stanford University
Guest Lectures:	
2024, 2025	<i>Developmental Language Disorder</i> , Introduction to Communication Disorders (CSD 203)
2018	<i>Atypical Language Development</i> , Current Topics in Psychology Course (Psych 601) Studying language development inside and outside the lab, UW-Madison
2016	<i>Language Development</i> , Cognitive Development Course (Psychology 502), UW-Madison
2016	<i>Word Learning</i> , Child Development Course (Psychology 560), UW-Madison

Professional Service

2022-	Ambassador, Raising Awareness of Developmental Language Disorder (RADLD)
2018-	Ad-Hoc Reviewer <i>Child Development</i> <i>Developmental Psychology</i> <i>Journal of Speech, Language, and Hearing Research</i> <i>Journal of Cognition and Development</i> <i>Cognitive Development</i> <i>Cognitive Science</i> <i>Language, Speech, and Hearing Services in Schools</i> <i>International Journal of Speech-Language Pathology</i> <i>American Journal of Speech-Language Pathology</i> <i>Journal of Autism and Developmental Disorders</i> <i>Autism Research</i> <i>Autism and Developmental Language Impairments</i>
2013-2019	Program Committee Symposium on Research in Child Language Disorders (SRCLD) Communication Sciences and Disorders, UW-Madison
2014-2015	Young Science Scholar University-Community partnership to improve Elementary School Science Education <i>I worked with teachers at Sandburg Elementary School to help revise their science curricula and co-taught science lessons once per week.</i>

Departmental Service

2025-	College Advisory Council
2025-	Graduate (MA) Admissions Committee
2024	Faculty Search Committee